Newspapers.com by Ancestry
https://www.newspapers.com/image/507129723/

Times Colonist (Victoria, British Columbia, Canada) · Fri, Jun 4, 1971 · Page 21
Downloaded on Oct 4, 2024

41 LOCAL FAMILIES DISRUPTED, LITTLE WORK SEEN

Another Side Exists to Sunro Decision

By DON VIPOND

The men who would have worked Sunro mine near Jordan River say there's another side to this week's story of the mine being denied a permit to discharge tailings into Juan de Fuca Strait.

It's the story of 50 men who have already been laid off and the remaining four who will be. And the 100 to 125 men the mine would have employed when it went into full production.

Of the 54 men hired last fall when the mine was rehabilitated, 41 have homes and families in Greater Victoria. Some have lived in the area for years.

The families have an average of two children so the permit decision cuts right to the core of life for at least 163 men, women and children settled here.

When Dison Development Ltd. announced reactivation of the former Cowichan copper mine with financial backing from a giant French firm, the men hired at the outset were jubilant. They made plans, started additions to their homes. The payroll at the mine averaged $1,000 a man per month.

Plans and hopes vanished with a jolt Tuesday when the Pollution Control Branch announced it had rejected the mine's application to discharge up to a million gallons of effluent into the strait daily.

Lloyd Delaney, a miner and president of Local 1012 of the United Steelworkers, Alan Iverson, motorman at the mine, and Joe Kereszti, an electrician, made these points in an interview today.

Apart from the hardship which faces them and those like them now out of work, the whole community loses.

The mine in operation would have spent $6 million a year for supplies, equipment and services. They say it would have added a secondary $100,000 a month to the area payroll.

Money and jobs aside, they're puzzled by other questions.

Sunro, if it had achieved maximum production, would have pumped a million gallons of mine effluent, 80 per cent water, 20 per cent rock crushed to sand, into the strait below tideline.

The Pollution Control Branch wouldn't allow that but just a few months ago granted a permit to Utah mine near Port Hardy to pump up to 9,300,000 gallons of effluent into Rupert Inlet daily.

The strait is open with strong tidal currents. Rupert Inlet is practically landlocked, they note.

Utah's mill has a capacity of 33,000 tons a day and its effluent is concentrated. Sunro's had a capacity of 1,000 tons a day and its effluent wasn't nearly so concentrated.

The Annaconda copper mine at Britannia Beach has been dumping tailings at the edge of Howe Sound for about half a century, they add.

The fishing in Howe Sound remains good, so the Sunro men are at a loss to understand objections from commerical fishermen to the Jordan River operation.

There would have been residual traces of cyanide in the Sunro tailings but well below official safety levels. Cyanide is used in separating mineral from rock.

Sunro can appeal the PCB's ruling on the permit but the men say the French backers are free now to pull their financing out at any time. The question is: will they wait for an appeal?

Meanwhile, jobs are far from handy for Sunro's former mine workers.

There are only two other mines on Vancouver Island which might be able to hire a handful of the unemployed men. They are Western at Buttle Lake and Benson Lake, about 26 miles northwest of Port McNeil.

80% Water, 20% Sand: Is That Real Pollution?

Copyright © 2024 Newspapers.com. All Rights Reserved.